

some native showed them exactly where to look. She probes the complex networks between exploration, discovery, documentation, appropriation, and colonialism. In the frantic travel of recent years, especially the revenge tourism that followed the pandemic, wanderlust is reduced to another kind of consumption, one that signals virtue and intelligence.

There are chapters in which Habib seems to throw in everything, as in the one on Indian train travel, which somehow also covers the cotton-slaves-sugar loop that made Britain and the United States rich. But the fact is that all of these bits of history do hang together.

Without oversimplifying or grandstanding, Habib has a readable and engaging way of telling her history. In more personal chapters, she writes of her father, a true cosmopolitan, who makes a strong case for staying at home, and her own flaneury on Brooklyn buses with her infant daughter. She writes of her hometown Ernakulam, Fort Kochi's frumpy sister. These interludes in her history of travel remind us of the peaceable places in which many of us live and work. Aren't we grateful no one's gone and discovered them? ■

–Latha Anantharaman

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Roy is critical of writers and schools of thought in whose works she notices "exclusions". Thus, "the Subaltern Studies project has been, for all purposes and in spite of its best intentions, a metropolitan project". T.S. Eliot's essay 'What Is a Classic?' is found wanting on many counts. Roy provides an unbiased view about provincials too, notably the "professional provincial reader" often guided by literary awards and festivals. At the heart of this book is the universal desire to be seen and heard. I grew up in Darjeeling, near Roy's hometown, Siliguri, around the same time as she did, the 1980s. Reflected here were parts of my story, taking on different meanings with the advantage of experience and hindsight. ■

–Vineeta Rai

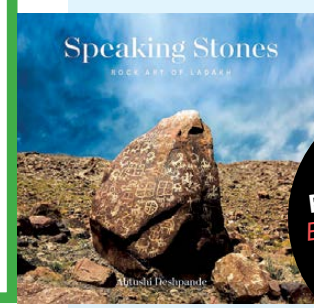
BOOKS

Museum Under the Sky

Photographer **Ahtushi Deshpande**'s passion project, *Speaking Stones* documents the threatened rock art of Ladakh

"The real voyage of discovery consists not in seeking new landscapes, but in having new eyes" **—Marcel Proust**

Ladakh is now a cliché of landscape photography; the grand slopes and vistas pockmarked by Instagram pins spread into a yawn of familiarity. That Ahtushi Deshpande manages to take the eye into fresh visual discoveries in an overphotographed terrain is the compelling reason to traverse through *Speaking Stones*, her self-published book on the petroglyphs, the ancient rock etchings of Ladakh.



SPEAKING STONES
Rock Art of Ladakh
By Ahtushi Deshpande
SELF-PUBLISHED
₹4,500; 220 pages

Unknown to the gaze of tourists is a spread of numerous (about 600) rock sites scattered throughout Ladakh, with intricate prehistoric carvings that are breathtakingly detailed traces of a living culture. The carvings, etched into the deep brown patina of the rocks to reveal a lighter brown shade, range from prehistoric depictions of hand impressions, hunting scenes, community gatherings and dances, to ornately detailed forms of animals like ibex, antelopes, yaks, Bactrian camels, birds and snow leopards, and on to later Buddhist-era engravings of stupas. The different styles of petroglyphs, the early matchstick shapes, evolving into triangular anthropomorphic forms and the more ornate curvilinear depictions of animal bodies reveal the layered sedimentation of life and central Asian culture in this remote region.

The book is divided into six sections, each taking the reader into separate regions of Ladakh with their specific petroglyph sites. The core images are documentary in nature. But infused with the gaze of a fine landscape photographer, the depictions of rock engravings are strikingly sharp and rich in textural detail. From the grand spatiality of the sweeping landscape, Ahtushi astutely zooms in to show the placement of the 'rock canvases' in the middle of the terrain. She then reveals the intricate closeups of the etchings which are contextualised with the accompanying photographs of the material culture of Ladakh.

The artistic framing of the etched rocks with varying emphasis of light and shade helps the viewer experience the anthropological nature of the subject through a filter of aesthetic delight. Swiss scholar Martin Vernier, a researcher of the petroglyphs of Ladakh, and a fellow writer of the book, lauds Ahtushi's work as a "bridge for a wider audience facilitating a deeper understanding of the subject" of Himalayan rock art.

For the eye to locate such elusive details amidst a sprawling grand colosseum of nature is an act of silencing the self, deploying focus like a pinhole. It is the handiwork of a monk soul. This book is the photographer painting her gompha. ■

–Bandeep Singh